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The logo for ARLnow is displayed in white against a dark blue background. The background is a photograph of a city skyline at night, with several tall buildings illuminated. The word 'ARL' is in a large, bold, sans-serif font, and 'now' is in a smaller, italicized, sans-serif font.

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Local is everything

Around Town

Local ‘Geezers’ use lunch gatherings to keep tabs on Arlington politics

By **Scott McCaffrey**

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Members of the Geezers at Dec. 3, 2025, luncheon gathering (staff photo by Scott McCaffrey)

With age comes wisdom — sometimes, at least — and in the case of one Arlington group of civic leaders, it brings a sense of humor, too.

They call themselves the Geezers. Among their ranks are two retired judges, a trio of former elected officials, several lobbyists and — a Geezer-in-waiting — the current clerk of the circuit court.

Though leaning Democratic, membership is open to those of Republican and independent inclinations, as well.

Those currently part of the group:

- Retired Clerk of the Circuit Court [David Bell](#)
- Semi-retired Juvenile & Domestic Relations District Court Judge [George Varoutsos](#)

- Retired Sheriff [James Gondles](#)
- Retired circuit court judge and former member of the House of Delegates [James Almand](#)
- Government-affairs professionals [Scott McGeary](#), [Rex Wackerle](#) and [Jim Turpin](#)

The youngster of the group is current Clerk of the Circuit Court, and former County Board member, [Paul Ferguson](#). Earlier this year, Ferguson turned 60, a milestone that may stun those who remember his first election to local office at the age of 30.

Ferguson was, at the time of his election in 1995, Arlington's youngest ever County Board member. He later shared that distinction with Katie Cristol, also 30 at her [election in 2015](#). Both were surpassed by current Board member Maureen Coffey, who was 28 when [elected in 2023](#).

The Geezers meet four to six times per year, with hosting duties rotating among members. For the Dec. 3 luncheon, Wackerle selected Tupelo Honey in the Courthouse area.

Most live locally, although McGeary now resides in the Winchester area and Gondles typically flies in from his current home in South Florida.

The Geezers owe their existence to the late county Treasurer [Frank O'Leary](#), who founded the ad-hoc group and led it until his death in June 2024.

One of O'Leary's last public outings was a luncheon with the group. Because he had been ill, most of the members knew it was likely to serve as a final farewell, Ferguson said.

Three days after the luncheon, O'Leary died.



Clerk of Court Paul Ferguson with Geezers founder Frank O'Leary in mid-2024 (courtesy James Gondles)

For those in attendance on Dec. 3, there was much to catch up on, both political and personal. Arlington native Varoutsos had recently published a memoir (“An Overachieving Forrest Gump”) and lobbyist Turpin soon will head to Richmond and his 50th session of the General Assembly.

Turpin’s tenure in Richmond began in 1976 as a legislative intern for the Virginia Municipal League. It has included periods as an aide in both the Senate and House of Delegates, party-caucus director, trade association representative and contract lobbyist.

Starting out on the Republican side of the aisle, Turpin switched sides in 1988 and has been active in Democratic politics ever since.

McGeary, by contrast, has stayed in the Republican fold. An Arlington native and veteran government-affairs professional, he long represented Washington Gas in both Richmond and Annapolis before retiring earlier this year.

Admittance to the Geezers is by invitation only.

“There’s no record check — obviously, with this group,” chuckled Bell, who served as clerk of court from 1977 until being succeeded by Ferguson in 2007.

In retirement, Bell served several stints on the Arlington Electoral Board, including one in tandem with McGeary.

One can be either employed or retired. “I was still working at the courthouse when he invited me,” Varoutsos recalled of O’Leary’s offer to join.

Though retired as a full-time state jurist since late 2021, Varoutsos often travels across the commonwealth to serve as a substitute judge.

Guests are invited to sit in on occasion. Previous visitors have included political leaders like Richard Saslaw, Charles Robb and Jim Moran.

The group is still attempting to nab former Rep. [Tom Davis](#) (R-11), who grew up in Arlington and attended local schools with his friend Almand.

About the Author



Scott McCaffrey

A Northern Virginia native, Scott McCaffrey has four decades of reporting, editing and newsroom experience in the local area plus Florida, South Carolina and the eastern panhandle of West Virginia. He spent 26 years as editor of the Sun Gazette newspaper chain. For Local News Now, he covers government and civic issues in Arlington, Fairfax County and Falls Church.

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